



Leader's Guide: Navigating the 1:1 Well-Being Conversation

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1. Background and Objectives

High levels of stress and burnout in the workplace continue to impact employee wellbeing and engagement with 41% of employees globally experiencing significant daily stress, and only 23% feeling engaged in their work (Gallup 2024 State of the Global Workplace Report). In McKinsey's Global Survey 2022, 25% of workers globally reported experiencing burnout.

Stress and burnout are major contributors to long-term sickness, increased absenteeism, high employee turnover, and reduced employee engagement and productivity. In the United Kingdom, 2.5 million workers are out of work due to long term illness (Office for National Statistics 2023).

Identifying the early signs of stress and burnout in your employees and having regular 1:1 wellbeing check-ins can help create a supportive and trusting environment where people can thrive.

The objective of the 1:1 wellbeing session is simply to engage in a conversation that is entirely focused on the individual, to understand how they are feeling, how they are coping with the challenges that they are facing and how well they are managing their work/life balance.

This brief document provides some guidance on preparing for the conversation, establishing a safe environment, some typical questions that we can ask, how to respond to what we hear, as well as some 'dos and don'ts' during the conversation. There is also the 'stress v performance' curve that can be used to support the conversation in Appendix 1 at the end of the guide.

Objectives of the 1:1 Well-being Conversation

- To understand how they are feeling, really feeling about themselves.
- How they are coping with the challenges they face at work and at home.
- How they are managing their work/life balance.
- To offer support and understanding where needed.
- To identify any team members who may require additional support.
- To create a safe, open trusting environment.

2. Creating the right environment

It's essential that we create the right environment for the conversation to ensure that we establish an open dialogue without distractions or interruptions.

It's also important to set up a separate session focused entirely on this topic rather than taking 5 minutes at the start of a regular work-related call which will have little impact and may even create a negative effect as it may be perceived that this topic isn't important enough to warrant more time.

When it comes to the environment itself, it's important that we establish a quiet environment without distraction. If you are both located in the same office, then schedule a face-to-face session in a small meeting room rather than an open plan area to make the person you are meeting feel more comfortable.

Alternatively schedule a Zoom/Teams call at a convenient time and be sensitive to time zone differences particularly as this conversation is all about the well-being of our people.

Avoid scheduling a session when either of you are driving, at an airport, gym etc. It gives the wrong impression and is unlikely to result in an open, productive conversation.

Schedule enough time for the conversation so that it doesn't appear rushed. The recommendation is for 30-45 minutes for each person. It's important to give people the opportunity and time and space to share how they are feeling.

It's also important to be 100% present in the conversation, whether face to face or via Zoom/Teams, so make sure that you turn off your phone, and notifications.

Key Points

- Schedule a session that is dedicated to this topic.
- If in the office find a comfortable, quiet environment or set up a Zoom/Teams call.
- Schedule enough time so the conversation doesn't appear rushed (30-45 mins).
- Turn off your phone and notifications so there are no distractions.
- Avoid having the call when either of you are travelling or in a noisy environment.

3. Starting the Conversation

Firstly, we need to establish the context of the conversation and why the well-being of the employee is important to you and the company. We also need to establish a psychologically safe environment for our people to feel comfortable talking about themselves and the challenges they are facing.

One way to do this is to acknowledge that we are in a challenging environment with constant change and uncertainty both at work and in the wider global context which can increase the level of stress and anxiety.

Share how you are feeling. Be vulnerable, open and authentic and share a brief story about yourself that relates to the topic that demonstrates empathy and an understanding of the situation.

For example.

'There just aren't enough hours in the day, and I am finding it hard to find time for myself and my family.'

'Change is constant, and I find it hard to stay on top of things and manage a good work/life balance.'

Confirm the objective of the session is to simply 'check-in' with the individual to understand how they are feeling and how they are coping with the day-to-day challenges at work and at home.

Finally, confirm before you start that the conversation is confidential and encourage them to be as open and honest as possible and that you are here to support and help them.

Key Points

- Establish the context of the session and why the wellbeing of our people is important to you and the company.
- Acknowledge that we are in a challenging environment with rapid change.
- Share how you are feeling and be authentic, open and vulnerable and share an example.
- Explain that the objective of the session is simply to understand how they are, and how they are feeling.
- Confirm that the conversation is confidential and encourage them to be open and honest about how they are feeling.

4. Asking Open Questions

Generally, we need to be asking 'open' coaching style questions to stimulate conversation and then be in a position to follow the response with a clarifying question to dive deeper into the topic. You will have some of your own questions but here are some ideas to select from;

- How are you feeling, how are things going? (Note that we often find that the response to the first question doesn't reveal much about the individual or their true state of mind, so we need to keep digging).
- How would you rate your overall well-being right now, say from 1-10?
 - Based on their answer, ask if for example if 6/10 is their normal state or if its better or worse than normal.
 - Ask them to explain the circumstances if its improved or got worse.
- What are the areas that cause you stress at work?
 - What impact does that have on you at work, and outside of work?
- Using the Stress v Performance curve (attached) ask them where they would place themselves now. Ask them to explain their answer.
- How are you managing your work/life balance?
 - What aspects are the most difficult to manage?
 - What impact does this have on you and your loved ones?
- Have you managed to set boundaries? Ask for examples.
- Are there any specific challenges or difficulties right now that you would like to discuss?
- How do you typically manage stress and pressure?
- What strategies do you rely on to manage stress and pressure?
- How well are you taking care of yourself lately? Ask for examples.
- Is your role, within the team clearly understood? If no, ask them to explain.
- How do you manage your workload and prioritise your work?
- Are the team's priorities and goals clearly understood? If no, ask for examples.
- How well do you feel supported by the team? Ask them to explain further.
- How comfortable do you feel asking for help when things get on top of you?
- Do you feel comfortable speaking up within your team? Explain.

- Are there any concerns or worries that occupy your thoughts lately?

Use the 'stress v performance' curve in Appendix 1 to help stimulate the conversation.

5. Active Listening

During the conversation, it's really important to be 'present', listening carefully to the person's response as they answer your question. Don't interrupt them mid flow and if they pause to reflect, use the silence effectively, giving them the time and space to enable them to continue.

Once they have finished their answer, it can be powerful to play what they have said back to them, to confirm your understanding adding a clarification question to dive deeper.

Don't be judgemental or defensive or try to justify a situation, just listen and also avoid the temptation to jump in and start trying to 'fix' the problem.

Try to put yourself in their shoes and show that you understand what they are saying and how they are feeling.

Listen and look out for other signals such as their tone of voice, and body language.

Be supportive, and sympathetic and offer help and support.

Key Points

- Be present and confirm your understanding through active listening.
- Avoid being judgemental and don't try to justify or defend their concerns.
- Avoid jumping in to fix a specific problem.
- Observe other signals which may help you understand how they are feeling.
- Show empathy and be supportive.

6. Closing the Conversation/Next Steps

Make time at the end of the session to ask for feedback about the conversation and confirm that your 'door is always open' and they shouldn't hesitate to reach out and ask for help.

Set the expectation that you would like to schedule a regular check-in every 1-2 months.

Ask them to think about a positive change that they can make to their Work/life balance by setting boundaries/making regular time for themselves, family or friends.

If it is clear they are really struggling and feel uncomfortable talking to you, encourage them to seek professional help. Reference any programmes that exist within the company that are available to employees.

Key Points

- Ask them how they felt about the conversation.
- Indicate that you would like to have a regular session every 1- 2 months.
- Ask them to make a positive change to their work/life balance.
- Encourage them to seek professional help and support if it's clear they are really struggling.

Appendix 1 – Stress v Performance Curve



Explanation

The stress/performance curve pictured above looks at the relationship between performance on the vertical scale and stress on the horizontal scale. We all need a level of pressure to get to the 'sweet spot' of optimal performance, but when that pressure continues for an extended period of time, we may become exhausted.

If we remain in the exhaustion stage for a period of time, our performance starts to decline and unless we are able to step back and reset, it may lead to 'illness' or even 'burnout'. Illness is characterised by short periods of absence from work, whilst burnout is usually associated with extended periods of absence.

On the left-hand side of the curve, you may be 'bored', perhaps the role isn't testing your full capability or capacity. And the 'challenged' phase often relates to people who are unable to get to optimal performance, perhaps because they have recently joined the organisation and are coming up to speed, or perhaps something is preventing them from getting to optimal performance such as an unclear role or priorities, or conflict within a team.

Questions to Ask

Where do you sit on the stress v performance curve right now?

How does that differ from where you were 12 months ago?

If different, what has changed and what's driving that change?